# Cairn

## Cheat Sheet

*a rules summary for the game by Yochai Gal*
*fit for rules-light fantasy tabletop roleplaying*

General Principles: **Neutrality** *The Warden is a neutral arbiter to portray the world clearly* **Classless** *Specialities are defined by the characters' equipment and experiences* **Death** *It's always a threat, but never random or without warning* **Fiction First** *Success and failure derive from the context rather than dice* **Growth** *Characters change through in-world advancement and overcoming obstacles* **Player Choice** *Players should understand the reasons behind choices with potential risks provided freely* **Principles** *Warden and Players follow guidelines to foster critical thinking, exploration and emergent narrative* **Shared Objectives** *Players engage with the shared setting, goals and challenges together*

For The Players: **Agency** *Rely on intuition, items and connections more than attributes* **Teamwork** *Seek consensus and accomplish more together* **Exploration** *Ask about details to find more than one way forward* **Talking** *Treat NPCs like real people mostly acting in self-interest* **Caution** *Stack odds in your favor and retreat when it's unfavorable* **Planning** *Avoid obstacles through reconnaissance and research* **Ambition** *Earn reputation through own goals that keep things moving*

For The Warden: **Information** *Provide useful information freely and let the players keep asking* **Difficulty** *Default to context and realism to only roll for uncertain outcomes* **Preparation** *Develop situations organically through actions affecting the world* **Narrative Focus** *Induce emergent play along the needs of players, but with consequences* **Danger** *Telegraph dangerous threats more obvious with opportunities to solve the problem* **Treasure** *Lure players to a valuable item that tells a story but often entails trouble* **Choice** *Give players solid choices that move the situations forward*

---

# Character

## ◆ Attributes

Attributes are not universal descriptors, they just determine the risk of actions.

**Strength** (STR) 3d6
*physical power, like lifting gates, bending bars, resisting poison, etc.*

**Dexterity** (DEX) 3d6
*poise, speed, reflexes, dodging, climbing, sneaking, balancing, etc.*

**Willpower** (WIL) 3d6
*persuade, deceive, interrogate, intimidate, charm, provoke, manipulate spells, etc.*

**Hit Protection** (HP) 1d6
*character's ability to avoid damage in combat, depleted like stamina*

- save with 1d20 ≤ attribute
- 1 always succeeds, 20 always fails
- whoever most at risk should save
- 1d6 for uncertain events

## ◆ Inventory

All items on a character are part of their inventory providing them capabilities.

**Inventory slots** are 10 (4-5 w/o backpack)
*expanded with carts, wagons, pack animals, hirelings, etc.*

**Items** occupy 0, 1, 2 slots
*a petty cloak, regular gambeson and bulky chainmail for example*

**Fatigue** (f) occupies 1 slot
*obtained when deprived, casting spells and from events in fiction*

**Spellbooks** occupy 1 slot
*contain one spell to be cast, are unique and attract attention*

**Scrolls** occupy 0 slots
*contain one spell to be cast once and disappear afterwards*

**Relics** are special items
*imbued with a magical spell or power, of limited use and with a recharge condition*

**Armor** (ARM) 0-3 max
*from items worn or held*

- full inventory reduces HP to 0
- multiple uses (u) for certain items

**Starting equipment** includes
- 3d6 coins, rations (3u) and a torch (3u)
- 3 items or less from background
- 1 weapon and 1 armor
- 1 additional gear

## ◆ Background

Abilities and privileges often derive from who the character is in the world.

**Traits** for character's appearance
*Age, Physique, Skin, Hair, Face, Speech, Clothing, Virtue and Vice*

**Past** that led here
- what experiences formed the character
- should offer an item and/or ability

**Present** circumstances
- what broadly defines the PC today
- related to specific item or skill

**Bond** ties PC to the world
- item/ability encouraging engagement
- initiates quest, opportunity or plan

**Omen** seeds a looming adventure
- world peculiarities yet unknown
- slowly reveals something going on
- rolled once by youngest PC

# Dungeons

## ◆ Procedure

A round of dungeon exploration includes:

1. Warden describes room and dangers
2. Players state PCs intended actions
   1. Move up to 40ft (12m)
   2. Move again twice or do other action
3. Warden resolves actions together
4. Players record any new conditions
5. Warden rolls event if appropriate

**Dungeon events** are rolled when the party
- spends more than 1 round in a place
- moves into a new area, level or zone
- moves quickly/aimlessly through a room
- creates a loud disturbance

## ◆ Events

[1] **Encounter** *rolled on a suitable table, including NPC reaction*

[2] **Sign** *revealing a clue, spoor, lair, victim, etc.*

[3] **Environment** *surroundings shift or escalate, either location or NPCs*

[4] **Loss** *of a resource (torch light, active spell, etc.) to be resolved before moving on*

[5] **Exhaustion** *requiring a brief rest that adds fatigue or consumes rations*

[6] **Quiet**, *all alone and safe for the time being*

## ◆ Elements

**Actions** require effort
- time, skill, items, health, people, etc.

**Resting** requires light and safety
- restores HP but not fatigue

**Panicked** in darkness, fear or surrounded
- 0 HP, impaired, lose first combat round
- make WIL save to overcome condition

**Light** sources illuminate 40ft (12m)
- last until put out by character or event
- can be lit 3 times, some refill with oil

**Reactions** of NPCs rolled with 2d6
- hostile [2], wary [3-5], curious [6-8], kind [9-11], helpful [12]

**Hirelings** can accompany PCs
- with skill, knowledge and training
- created like a character

Gear (d100)

*Acid, Air Bladder, Alcohol, Antitoxin, Bandages (3u), Bell, Bellows, Blanket, Boltcutters* **10** *Bowl, Cage, Caltrops, Candle (3u, dim), Cards, Cart (+4 slots, bulky), Chain (10ft), Chalk (petty), Chisel, Climbing Spikes* **20** *Cloak (petty), Compass, Crowbar, Dice, Dowsing Rod, Explosive, Fan, Fiddle, Fire Oil, Fishing Rod* **30** *Flash Powder, Flour, Garrotte, Gloves (petty), Glue, Goggles, Grappling Hook, Grease, Hammer, Hammock* **40** *Hand Drill, Honey, Hourglass, Incense, Ladder (10 ft, bulky), Lantern, Leech (restores 1 STR, 3u), Lens, Lock & Key, Lockpick* **50** *Lodestone, Lute, Magnifying Glass, Manacles, Marbles, Mask, Metal File, Mirror, Mugwort, Net* **60** *Oil Can (6u), Oilskin Bag, Pail, Paint, Parchment & Ink (3u), Perfume, Pickaxe, Pipe, Pliers, Poison* **70** *Pole (10ft), Poncho (petty), Pulley, Random Spellbook, Rope (25ft), Sack, Saw, Scissors, Scroll of Random Spellbook (petty), Sealable Bottle* **80** *Sedative, Sewing Kit, Sextant, Shovel, Signal Flag, Smokebomb, Smoking Herbs (3u), Songbook, Spiked Boots, Spyglass* **90** *Stylus, Tar, Tent (fits 2, bulky), Tongs, Trap (d6 STR damage), Wagon (+8 slots, slow), Waterproof Bag, Whetstone, Whistle (petty), Wig Wolfsbane*

# Combat

## ◆ Procedure

A round of combat (~10s) includes:

1. (PCs lose first turn on failed DEX save)
2. All PCs take actions simultaneously
   1. Move up to 40ft (12m)
   2. Move again or do other action
3. All NPCs take actions simultaneously
4. Ends on defeat, flight or surrender

## ◆ Fighting

Attacks in combat always hit.

**Attack** rolling d6, d8 or d10
- d4 if **impaired**
- d12 if **enhanced**
- xdY highest for **multiple** weapons
- dY targets hit with **blast**

**Damage** of attack roll
- reduced by ARM
- excess reduces HP
- exactly to 0 gives **scar**
- excess reduces STR (critical)
- failed STR save makes **downed**
- NPCs are dead instead

**Ranged attacks** impaired on long distance
- too far if you can't see white in their eyes
- ammunition not usually tracked

**Retreat** requires a DEX save
- and a safe destination to run to

**Morale** checked for NPCs with WIL save
- when enemies take first casualty
- when they lose half their number
- some groups use leader's WIL
- lone foes must save at 0 HP

**Detachments** pool groups of similar foes
- or a large creature occasionally
- routed/split/struck on critical damage
- destroyed when STR reduced to 0
- 1 vs. detachment is impaired
- detachment vs. 1 is enhanced + blast

## ◆ Healing

**Attributes** can be reduced by events
- 0 STR is **dead**
- 0 DEX is **paralyzed**
- 0 WIL is **delirious**

**Deprived** when lacking crucial needs
- like food, water, rest, etc.
- adds 1 fatigue each day
- prevents recovering HP or attributes

**Restore HP** w/ brief rest + water

**Stabilize** downed character w/ bandages

**Restore attributes** w/ week's rest + healer

**On death** create a new character to join

## ◆ Magic

**Casting spells** can be done by anyone
- holding the spellbook in two hands
- reading its contents aloud
- adds 1 fatigue to inventory

**In danger or deprived** requires WIL save
- ill effects for failure on par with intent
- fatigue, damage, injury, death, etc.

**Enhancing spells** requires time and safety

**Scrolls** are petty variants
- disappearing after 1 use
- do not cause fatigue

**Relics** are imbued with power or spell
- of limited use with recharge condition
- do not cause fatigue

## ◆ Scars

Permanent effects of combat injuries.

[1] **Lasting scar** *HP = max(HP, 1d6), 1d6 for neck, hands, eye, chest, legs or ear*

[2] **Rattling blow** *HP = max(HP, 1d6) on refocus, disoriented and shaken*

[3] **Walloped** *HP = HP + 1d6 on recovery, deprived until rest for a few hours*

[4] **Broken limb** *HP = max(HP, 2d6) on recovery, 1d6 for legs, arms, rib or skull*

[5] **Diseased** *HP = max(HP, 2d6) on recovery, gross and uncomfortable infection*

[6] **Reorienting head wound** *attr = max(attr, 3d6), 1d6 for STR, DEX or WIL*

[7] **Hamstrung** *DEX = max(DEX, 3d6) on recovery, barely mobile until serious help*

[8] **Deafened** *WIL += 1d4 on WIL save, needs extraordinary aid to regain hearing*

[9] **Re-brained** *WIL = max(WIL, 3d6), hidden part of psyche knocked loose*

[10] **Sundered** *WIL += 1d6 on WIL save, appendage is torn off, crippled, or useless*

[11] **Mortal wound** *HP = 2d6 on recovery, deprived and out, dying in 1h unless healed*

[12] **Doomed** *HP = max(HP, 3d6) on crit save, dying horribly on failure*

### Armor & Weapons (d6)

**Armor** *Additional Gear (0), Shield (+1), Helmet (+1), Gambeson (+1), Chainmail (2, bulky), Plate (3, bulky)* **Weapons** *Dagger (d6), Sword (d8), Halberd (d10, bulky), Sling (d6), Bow (d6, bulky), Crossbow (d8, bulky)*

### Names (d100)

*Adair, Alaric, Alder, Amaris, Anwen, Arlo, Ash, Aster, Ballad* **10** *Barley, Basil, Beatrix, Birch, Bram, Briar, Brook, Bryn, Cai, Callan* **20** *Carver, Cedric, Cinder, Cliff, Corin, Crow, Dain, Darnel, Dax, Dorian* **30** *Eira, Elowen, Ember, Eon, Evander, Falcon, Faris, Fern, Finch, Flint* **40** *Freya, Gale, Garen, Hazel, Hemlock, Idris, Ivy, Juniper, Kael, Kavi* **50** *Keir, Leif, Liora, Lucan, Lyra, Lysander, Marius, Marlowe, Milo, Moss* **60** *Nazira, Neria, Noa, Nyx, Onyx, Orla, Pan, Patch, Perran, Quill* **70** *Rain, Reed, River, Robin, Rowan, Rune, Rush, Rye, Sable, Sage* **80** *Selene, Shade, Silas, Sky, Soren, Sparrow, Stellan, Stone, Storm, Talon* **90** *Thistle, Thorn, Thresh, Valen, Vesper, Vex, Willow, Winslow, Wisp, Wren Yarrow*

### Traits (d10)

**Age** *(2d20+10)* **Physique** *Athletic, Brawny, Flabby, Lanky, Rugged, Scrawny, Short, Statuesque, Stout, Towering* **Skin** *Birthmarked, Marked, Oily, Rosy, Scarred, Soft, Tanned, Tattooed, Weathered, Webbed* **Hair** *Bald, Braided, Curly, Filthy, Frizzy, Long, Luxurious, Oily, Wavy, Wispy* **Face** *Bony, Broken, Chiseled, Elongated, Pale, Perfect, Rakish, Sharp, Square, Sunken* **Speech** *Blunt, Booming, Cryptic, Droning, Formal, Gravelly, Precise, Squeaky, Stuttering, Whispery* **Clothing** *Antique, Bloody, Elegant, Filthy, Foreign, Frayed, Frumpy, Livery, Rancid, Soiled* **Virtue** *Ambitious, Cautious, Courageous, Disciplined, Gregarious, Honorable, Humble, Merciful, Serene, Tolerant* **Vice** *Aggressive, Bitter, Craven, Deceitful, Greedy, Lazy, Nervous, Rude, Vain, Vengeful*

# Wilderness

**Watches (w)** divide day into 3 segments
*morning, afternoon and night*

**Day** is 2w actions and 1w rest
*used as shorthand for travel time*

## ◆ Procedure

A round of exploration includes:

1. (Warden rolls for weather each day)
2. Warden describes location and paths
3. Players plot or adjust course
4. Players choose 1 action each
5. Warden narrates results
6. Warden rolls event (twice at night)
7. Players respond to results
8. All record any new conditions

## ◆ Events

[1] **Encounter** *rolled on a table specific to terrain or location, including NPC reaction*

[2] **Sign** *revealing a clue, spoor or indication of a nearby encounter, locality, feature, etc.*

[3] **Environment** *shift in weather or terrain*

[4] **Loss** *of resource, time, effort by tough choice*

[5] **Exhaustion** *encountering a barrier, forcing to spend time or add fatigue*

[6] **Discovery** *of food, treasure, other useful resources or a primary feature instead*

## ◆ Duration

Travel time between locations is determined by multiple factors adding up.

**Distance** between locations
- short (1w), medium (2w), long (3w)

**Terrain** (T) along the way
- easy (0w), tough (1w), perilous (2w)

**Path** connecting locations
- road (0w), trail (1w), wilderness (2w)

**Weather** during travel
- nice (0w), fair (0w), unpleasant (1w / 1f), inclement (1w / 1f + T↑), extreme (1w + 1f + T↑), catastrophic (no travel)
- extreme rolled twice makes catastrophic
- nighttime (1w) could negate hot weather
- roll 1d6 for current season:
  - `n f f u i e` (spring)
  - `n n f u i e` (summer)
  - `f f u i i e` (fall)
  - `f u i i e e` (winter)

**Reduced** by good preparation
- mounts, guides, maps, etc.
- spending resources or fatigue

## ◆ Actions

**Travel** to another location together
- reveals obvious locations and features
- get lost on trails (2/6) or wilderness (3/6)
- odds from path, maps, skills, guides
- recover way or end at near location
- T↑ traveling sleep-deprived

**Explore** current location
- search hidden features, scout ahead
- discovers location or feature

**Supply** with resources
- hunt, fish or forage for food
- 1/2/x people find 1d4/1d6/x rations
- experience/equipment increase bounty
- encountered houses resupply for coins

**Camp** set up in safe place
- PCs and mounts consume rations
- sleep unmolested with lookout rotation
- all able to rest lose all fatigue
- skipped camp makes deprived + 1f

# Downtime

**Activities** between game sessions
- one downtime action per PC at a time
- while safe and not recovering

**Milestones** track progress
- 1-5 complete, non-interactive tasks
- distinct for different strategies
- may change due to events in game

**Costs** often required for milestones
*e.g. coins, resources, reputation, loss*
- if unable to pay, find another way
- reduced by skill, connections and will
- with risks for failure

## ◆ Actions

**Research** investigation requires
- clearly formulated question
- source of knowledge in game world
- may spend action to find source

**Training** certain skills requires
- precise description what to improve
- master whom to train with
- inspired by experience in play
- clear narrative or mechanical result

**Strengthen Ties** in game world requires
- identified person or faction for ties
- specific intent (trust, membership, etc.)
- concrete measures to advance ties

# Growth

- tied to in-game experience affecting PC
- logical result of actions and events
- fosters further interaction with world
- makes character more interesting/fun
- may happen by cumulative experiences

## ◆ Triggers

PCs engaging in two of the following:
- acts consistent around single objective
- takes obvious risks of unknown effects
- interacts with unique item/being/entity

**Interacting with opaque** thing or being
*e.g. taking and ingesting heartseed*

**Long-term interaction** with spell or relic
*e.g. often using and manipulating spell*

**Forging relationship** with great power
*e.g. free deity trapped in a statue*

**Overcoming long-time** woe, misdeed, foe
*e.g. trap spirit of defeated serial murderer*

**Injury** or contamination
*e.g. eat decomposed after fungal infection*

**Learning** through trial and error
*e.g. throw net in combat repeatedly*

**Success/failure** despite natural talent
*e.g. sneaking successfully despite low dexterity*

**Faction advancement**
*e.g. complete initiation to an order*

**Resolution** of bond or omen
*e.g. cure stone heart as instructed*

**Acolyte** *Incense, Parchment & Ink (3u), Random Spellbook* **Acrobat** *Pole, Rope, Smokebomb* **Alchemist** *Acid, Lens, Oilskin Bag* **Apothecary** *Antitoxin, Bandages (3u), Sealable Bottle* **Assassin** *Garrotte, Mask, Poison* **Astrologer** *Candle (3u, dim), Marbles, Spyglass* **Baker** *Flour, Honey, Sealable Bottle* **Barber-Surgeon** *Bandages (3u), Scissors, Sedative* **Barkeep** *Alcohol, Sealable Bottle, Sedative* 10 **Beadle** *Bell, Gloves (p), Whistle (p)* **Beekeeper** *Fire Oil, Gloves (p), Honey* **Bell Ringer** *Gloves (p), Rope, Whistle (p)* **Bird Keeper** *Cage, Net, Whistle (p)* **Blacksmith** *Bellows, Hammer, Iron Tongs* **Bookbinder** *Glue, Parchment & Ink (3u), Sewing Kit* **Bounty Hunter** *Flash Powder, Manacles, Rope* **Butcher** *Pail, Saw, Whetstone* **Carpenter** *Hammer, Metal File, Saw* **Cartographer** *Compass, Parchment & Ink (3u), Sextant* 20 **Cartwright** *Hand Drill, Pulley, Saw* **Chandler** *Candle (3u, dim), Honey, Perfume* **Charlatan** *Cards, Paint, Perfume* **Chimney Sweep** *Bellows, Climbing Spikes, Rope* **Clockmaker** *Magnifying Glass, Metal File, Pliers* **Cobbler** *Pliers, Sack, Sewing Kit* **Cook** *Flour, Pail, Smoking Herbs (3u)* **Cooper** *Hammer, Hand Drill, Saw* **Courier** *Bell, Compass, Parchment & Ink (3u)* **Crypt Custodian** *Incense, Lantern, Oil Can (6u)* 30 **Cultist** *Incense, Mask, Scroll of Random Spellbook (p)* **Demolitionist** *Explosive, Goggles, Grease* **Dowser** *Dowsing Rod, Sealable Bottle, Shovel* **Duelist** *Cloak (p), Gloves (p), Whetstone* **Entertainer** *Dice, Songbook, Wig* **Executioner** *Mask, Rope, Whetstone* **Falconer** *Cage, Gloves (p), Whistle (p)* **Farmer** *Rope, Sack, Shovel* **Fence** *Bolt Cutters, Random Additional Gear, Sack* **Fisher** *Air Bladder, Fishing Rod, Net* 40 **Fletcher** *Sack, Trap, Whetstone* **Gambler** *Alcohol, Cards, Dice* **Gardener** *Gloves (p), Sack, Shovel* **Glassblower** *Goggles, Lens, Pliers* **Gong Farmer** *Gloves (p), Sack, Shovel* **Gravedigger** *Alcohol, Ladder, Shovel* **Guard** *Lantern, Manacles, Whistle (p)* **Herald** *Mask, Signal Flag, Whistle (p)* **Herbalist** *Antitoxin, Mugwort, Sack* **Hermit** *Blanket, Pole, Smoking Herbs (3u)* 50 **Highway Robber** *Grappling Hook, Rope, Signal Flag* **Hunter** *Trap, Rope, Smoking Herbs (3u)* **Illusionist** *Candle (3u, dim), Flash Powder, Mirror* **Innkeeper** *Alcohol, Bandages (3u), Parchment & Ink (3u)* **Jailer** *Chain, Manacles, Whistle (p)* **Jester** *Cards, Lute, Perfume* **Jeweler** *Magnifying Glass, Pliers, Tongs* **Knight** *Gloves (p), Signal Flag, Whetstone* **Lamplighter** *Ladder (10ft, b), Oil Can (6u), Whistle (p)* **Leech Collector** *Gloves (p), Leech (restores 1 STR, 3u), Net* 60 **Librarian** *Candle (3u, dim), Parchment & Ink (3u), random Scroll (p)* **Locksmith** *Lock & Key, Metal File, Pliers* **Lumberjack** *Rope, Saw, Whetstone* **Mason** *Chisel, Fan, Hammer* **Merchant** *Random Additional Gear, Stylus, Wagon (+8s, slow)* **Miller** *Bowl, Flour, Rope* **Miner** *Lantern, Lodestone, Pickaxe* **Monk** *Candle (3u, dim), Cloak (p), Songbook* **Musician** *Bowl, Fiddle, Songbook* **Naturalist** *Hammock, Rope, Spyglass* 70 **Navigator** *Compass, Poncho (p), Spyglass* **Oil Collector** *Lantern, Oil Can (6u), Sealable Bottle* **Painter** *Paint, Parchment & Ink (3u), Stylus* **Peddler** *Cart (+4s, b), Random Additional Gear, Sack* **Philosopher** *Chalk (p), Parchment & Ink, Pipe* **Physician** *Antitoxin, Bandages (3u), Crowbar* **Pilgrim** *Blanket, Pole, Poncho (p)* **Potter** *Chisel, Pail, Tongs* **Priest** *Bandages (3u), Candle (3u, dim), Incense* **Prospector** *Lantern, Lodestone, Pickaxe* 80 **Rat Catcher** *Sack, Trap, Whistle (p)* **Sailor** *Hammock, Rope, Spyglass* **Scribe** *Candle (3u, dim), Parchment & Ink (3u), Stylus* **Shepherd** *Cloak (p), Rope, Whistle (p)* **Smuggler** *Lock & Key, Oilskin Bag, Rope* **Soldier** *Spiked Boots, Tent (fits 2, b), Whetstone* **Spy** *Disguise Kit, Garrotte, Mirror* **Stablehand** *Blanket, Rope, Shovel* **Street Preacher** *Bell, Parchment & Ink, Scroll of Random Spellbook (p)* **Tailor** *Cloak (p), Scissors, Sewing Kit* 90 **Tanner** *Gloves (p), Pliers, Tar* **Tax Collector** *Parchment & Ink (3u), Sealable Bottle, Whistle (p)* **Thief** *Caltrops, Grappling Hook, Lockpick* **Tinker** *Grease, Hammer, Pliers* **Toll Keeper** *Bell, Lock & Key, Waterproof Bag* **Toymaker** *Glue, Pliers, Scissors* **Vagabond** *Blanket, Poncho (p), Rope* **Vintner** *Alcohol, Rope, Sealable Bottle* **Weaver** *Perfume, Rope, Scissors* **Witch** *Candle (3u, dim), Spellbook, Wolfsbane* **Witchfinder** *Rope, Scroll of Random Spellbook (p), Spyglass*

---